Name

Jackie Wirz

Address

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How long have you lived at your current address?

12 years

Phone Number

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How would you prefer to be contacted?

Email

1. What motivated you to apply for a position on the school board? Please include any experiences you have had with the school district as a parent, student, educator, or community member, nonprofit or public board.

My motivation to apply for a position on the Portland Public School District Board for Zone 1 stems from a deep commitment to equity, education, and community development.

For example, as the Executive Director of Saturday Academy, I oversaw education programs during the COVID-19 pandemic. I led the shift to digital learning, creating 60,000 hours of classes and internships with a focus on supporting underrepresented populations. This highlights the transformative power of accessible, high-quality education and the importance of innovation and adaptability in meeting student needs.

I sit on several education-focused boards, including Women in Science PDX, Workforce Talent and Development Board, and Odyssey Site Council. In these roles, I work to expand access to education, support diverse learners, and advocate for systemic change.

As a bipolar, BIPOC parent to a PPS student with high anxiety, I understand the importance of fostering inclusive environments where all students feel seen, valued, and capable of success.

By joining the Board, I aim to leverage my strategic thinking, equity-focused leadership, and community engagement skills to ensure every student—regardless of background—has the resources and opportunities they need to thrive.

2. What is your understanding of the primary functions and responsibilities of a public school board?

Based on my discussions with board members at PPS and beyond, I understand that the primary functions and responsibilities of a public school board include 1) Policy Leadership: Establishing policies that ensure high-quality education for all students; 2) Fiscal Oversight: Reviewing and adopting the budget and ensuring resources are allocated effectively to support district goals; 3) Superintendent Oversight: Hiring, setting goals for, supporting, and evaluating the Superintendent, while allowing them the autonomy to manage daily operations; 4) Community Engagement: working with the community, actively listening to public comments, and reflecting on feedback to inform decision-making; 5) Strategic Planning: Setting explicit goals and priorities for the district, focusing on policymaking, monitoring, and evaluation to further these objectives.

The board's role is strategic and high-level, ensuring schools operate effectively through strong governance and oversight. This understanding aligns with my experience on nonprofit and public boards, where strategic oversight, policy leadership, and community engagement are essential for achieving organizational goals.

3. How would you prioritize issues such as academic achievement, equity, student mental health, and teacher support? Can you give an example of a time you took action or provided leadership to prioritize an issue of importance.

I believe academic achievement, equity, student mental health, and teacher support are interconnected priorities that require holistic strategies. Academic achievement is rooted in equitable access to resources, robust mental health support, and a well-supported teaching staff. Equity must underpin all decisions, ensuring every student has the opportunity to succeed regardless of background. Mental health services are essential for fostering an environment where students and teachers can thrive, and teachers must be equipped with the tools and resources needed to create impactful learning experiences.

A time I demonstrated leadership to prioritize an important issue was during my tenure at OHSU. As the Confidential Advocate, I supported victims of sexual harassment and gender discrimination. Recognizing the critical need for comprehensive support services, I convened a grassroots coalition to advocate for expanded resources. My efforts led to securing an $800,000 VOCA grant, which established a dedicated department at OHSU to provide these essential services. This initiative exemplifies my commitment to addressing systemic challenges, building coalitions, and securing resources to create lasting change—an approach I would bring to the Portland Public School District Board.

4. How do you envision supporting students from diverse backgrounds and ensuring educational equity?

Supporting students from diverse backgrounds requires a student-centered approach that integrates systems-level change with practical, operational support. At OHSU, I led the Central Student Resources Council, convening 14 service departments to create a cohesive student support system. We developed shared goals and measurable objectives to improve outcomes across departments, promoting greater accountability and more effective service delivery.

As a board member, I would apply this same strategic mindset, fostering collaboration across departments to ensure resources are distributed equitably. By embedding equity in all aspects of district planning, I will ensure every student has the resources and support they need to succeed, particularly those from historically marginalized backgrounds.

5. What particular skills or expertise would you bring to the Board?

I bring a unique blend of data-driven decision-making, systems thinking, collaborative leadership, and a deep commitment to community and student well-being. My background in research, analysis, and strategic planning allows me to turn complex data into actionable insights. I prioritize listening and learning from those most impacted by policy decisions, ensuring that community voices are at the heart of the work.

My experience with cross-functional teams and communities has taught me how to build consensus and navigate differing perspectives. I have a strong track record of fostering equity and inclusion, ensuring that every student has access to the support they need to thrive. I am committed to using data

analytics in combination with community engagement to advocate for equitable, student-centered solutions.

6. How would you balance the needs of students, teachers, and the broader community when making decisions?

Balancing the needs of students, teachers, and the broader community requires an inclusive, transparent approach. First, I prioritize student well-being and academic success, ensuring that decisions reflect the diverse needs of our student population, particularly those from marginalized communities.

I use a systems approach to decision-making, considering how choices affect all stakeholders as a connected and interwoven network. This allows me to weigh the needs of students, teachers, and the broader community in a holistic manner. I would engage stakeholders through town halls, surveys, and advisory groups, ensuring that all perspectives are incorporated into decisions. By integrating the needs of students, valuing teacher input, and engaging the community, I will make balanced, transparent decisions that reflect shared priorities.

7. How do you think about the trade-offs in the school district's budgeting process?

When considering trade-offs in the school district's budgeting process, I focus on equity, sustainability, and impact. I recognize that every dollar allocated represents an opportunity to support student success, and I prioritize investments that have the most significant and lasting impact. This requires making difficult decisions, but I approach them with transparency and a clear rationale rooted in data and community input. By weighing short-term needs against long-term goals, I strive to ensure that resources are distributed equitably and that essential programs remain funded.

Budgeting is the ultimate expression of systems thinking, as it requires navigating the interconnections between financial resources, programmatic needs, and long-term district goals. My approach to budgeting reflects my broader commitment to systems thinking—considering how each decision reverberates through the larger educational ecosystem. By identifying patterns, understanding causal relationships, and balancing competing priorities, I ensure that budgetary decisions support sustainable, equitable outcomes for all stakeholders.

8. What experience do you have advocating for a cause, issue, campaign, legislation, etc?
Throughout my career, I have consistently advocated for equity, inclusion, and access. As chair of the Portland March for Science, I mobilized over 15,000 participants, advocating for science-based policy.

This event showcased my ability to bring together diverse communities and organizations to support a common cause. I ensured the event was safe and inclusive, demonstrating my skill in bridging different perspectives and fostering collective action.

My advocacy work is rooted in systems thinking, ensuring that each action supports broader, sustainable change. This approach allows me to advocate for policies that benefit students, teachers, and families.

9. What does diversity, equity, and inclusion mean to you in the context of public education? What is your lived experience that defines this perspective?

DEI in public education means creating environments where all students feel supported, valued, and empowered to succeed. It's about dismantling barriers to success and ensuring equitable access to education. DEI is not just about recognizing differences—it's about actively promoting inclusion and belonging.

As an adopted Asian-American growing up in rural Minnesota, I experienced discrimination and challenges in STEM. Later, I navigated the dual challenges of a neural disorder and bipolar disorder during graduate school. These experiences shaped my understanding of the importance of empathy, advocacy, and community support. Professionally, I have championed DEI through policy reform, training, and grant development, ensuring that decisions are made with equity at the core.

10. How would you work to address disparities in educational opportunities and outcomes for marginalized groups, including students of color, LGBTQ+ students, and students with disabilities?

I am committed to addressing disparities in educational opportunities for marginalized groups through a data-driven, systems approach. I would leverage data to identify achievement gaps and ensure that marginalized students are represented in decision-making processes. When there is insufficient data, I will advocate for methods that accurately and justly reflect these communities' needs.

By engaging directly with students, families, and community organizations, I will ensure that these groups' voices shape policies and practices. For students of color, I will advocate for inclusive curricula and expanded access to advanced coursework. For LGBTQ+ students, I will push for policies ensuring safety and inclusion. For students with disabilities, I will work to ensure that adequate resources, accommodations, and individualized support are available.

With a focus on equity and evidence-based practices, I will work to ensure that every student has the opportunity to succeed.